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SP24-BSE-107-A

Thematic Analysis Assignment

Topic: Duolingo – A language learning app

Interview 1 – Mark (Casual Learner, Age 24)

Interviewer: How would you describe your overall engagement with the app's gamified features?

Mark: It's a double-edged sword. The streak is what keeps me coming back, but it feels like a chore sometimes. If I'm busy, I just do a "streak freeze" lesson which doesn't really help me learn.

Interviewer: Can you tell me about any usability issues you've encountered while navigating the lessons?

Mark: Sometimes the buttons for the word bank are too small. On my phone, I often tap the wrong word by accident and lose a "heart," which is really annoying.

Interviewer: To what extent do you feel the app is effective in teaching you a new language for real-world use?

Mark: It's great for vocabulary, but I'd be lost in a real conversation. It doesn't explain why a sentence is structured a certain way; it just tells me I'm wrong.

Interviewer: What specific obstacles or frustrations do you face during your daily learning routine?

Mark: The notifications are too aggressive. If I haven't practiced by noon, the owl starts "guilt-tripping" me. It makes me want to delete the app rather than open it.

Interviewer: Are there any UI elements or notifications that you find particularly confusing or distracting? **Mark:** The "Leagues" section. I don't really understand how the points are calculated, and seeing people with 10,000 points makes me feel like I'm failing.

Codes:

1. Gamification burnout
2. Inaccessible UI (Small buttons)
3. Lack of grammar explanations
4. Aggressive Notifications
5. Confusing gamification logic

.erview 2 – Elena (Professional, Age 39)

Interviewer: How would you describe your overall engagement with the app's gamified features?

Elena: I like the animations, but the leaderboards are distracting. I find myself playing to "win" the league rather than actually focusing on the French I'm supposed to be learning.

Interviewer: Can you tell me about any usability issues you've encountered while navigating the lessons?

Elena: The "Speaking" exercises often glitch. I'll say the correct phrase clearly, but the app says it can't hear me or marks it red. I usually just turn those off now.

Interviewer: To what extent do you feel the app is effective in teaching you a new language for real-world use?

Elena: It's okay for the basics, but the sentences are weird. Like, I don't need to know how to say "The horse is eating an apple under the table" in a business meeting.

Interviewer: What specific obstacles or frustrations do you face during your daily learning routine?

Elena: The "Heart System." If I make five mistakes while trying to learn a hard concept, I'm locked out unless I pay or wait. It punishes me for actually trying to learn.

Interviewer: Are there any UI elements or notifications that you find particularly confusing or distracting?

Elena: The path is very long now. It's hard to scroll back and find a specific grammar lesson I did last week. The organization feels a bit messy.

Codes:

1. Distracting Competetive features
2. Technical glitches (voice recognition)
3. Irrelevent Content
4. Heart System Penalties
5. Confusing navigation/organization

Interview 3 – David (Student, Age 20)

Interviewer: How would you describe your overall engagement with the app's gamified features?

David: I love the gems and the shop, but the ads after every single lesson are exhausting. It breaks my flow and makes me lose interest after just five minutes.

Interviewer: Can you tell me about any usability issues you've encountered while navigating the lessons?

David: Sometimes the audio doesn't play for the listening tasks. I have to restart the app to get the sound back, which is a major pain when I'm on the bus.

Interviewer: To what extent do you feel the app is effective in teaching you a new language for real-world use?

David: I feel like I'm just matching symbols. I can pass a level, but if you asked me to write a paragraph from scratch, I couldn't do it. There's not enough "free-form" practice.

Interviewer: What specific obstacles or frustrations do you face during your daily learning routine?

David: The difficulty spikes. It goes from "The cat is blue" to complex past-tense verbs with no explanation in between. It's a huge jump.

Interviewer: Are there any UI elements or notifications that you find particularly confusing or distracting?

David: The "Super Duolingo" pop-ups. They appear so often that I've almost accidentally clicked "Buy" several times. It feels very pushy.

Codes:

1. Monetization interface (Ads)
2. Technical glitches (Audio playback)
3. Shallow pedagogical depth
4. Inconsistent difficulty scaling
5. Intrusive UI pop-ups

Final Themes

(i) Psychological Friction & Engangement

Gamification burnout, Aggressive Notifications

(ii) Useability & Technical Barriers

Technical glitches, Inaccessible UI

(iii) Learning & Instructional Limitations

Shallow pedagogical depth, Irrelevent Content

(iv) Monetization & Progress Obstacles

Heart system penalties, Monetization interface